# *Greek Through Reading* Excerpts

March 9, 2026

Adapted readings from J. A. Nair & G. A. Nairn's *Greek Through Reading*, 1974 edition. This book is really special to me — it was a gift from Dr. Hendrickson, the Latin teacher at my high school who got me into Greek. I'd started studying in 2023 after taking his "How to Read Ancient Greek" mini class at summer camp. Two years later, in summer 2025, I took the same mini class, now having finished half of *Alpha to Omega*. He gave me the book there.

College apps prevented me from working through the book for most of 2025. Since I have more time now, I hope to work through most of its passages over summer 2026.

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## Greece and Athens

### Greece – J. A. Nairn

Ἡ Ἑλλὰς μέρος ἐστὶ τῆς Εὐρώπης. οἰκοῦσι δ᾽ αὐτὴν οἱ Ἕλληνας τοὺς πάλαι διὰ τοῦτο καὶ νῦν τιμῶμεν, ὅτι τήν τ᾽ ἐλευθερίαν ἐφίλουν, καὶ τὴν ἀλήθειαν, καὶ τὸ καλόν. καὶ ὑπὲρ μὲν τῆς ἐλευθερίας ὀλίγοι πρὸς πολλοὺς πολεμοῦντες πολλάκις ἐνίκησαν, τὴν δ᾽ ἀλήθειαν καὶ τὸ καλὸν ζητοῦντες ποιήματα καὶ δράματα καὶ ἱστορίας ἔγραψαν, καὶ ἀνδριάντας ἔγλυψαν καὶ ἱερὰ ᾠκοδόμησαν, ὧν ἔνια καὶ ἐφ᾽ ἡμῶν περίεστιν.

αὕτη ἡ βίβλος περὶ τῶν θ᾽ Ἑλλήνων καὶ περὶ τῶν ἔργων ἀπαγγελεῖ.

Greece is a part of Europe. And the Greeks live there. We now value the Ancient Greeks on account of these, because they were loving freedom, and the truth, and moral things[1]. And on account of freedom the few often conquered the many making war, and seeking truth and morals, wrote poems and plays and histories, and carved statues and erected shrines, of which some now are surviving in our time.[2]

This book will recount both the Greeks and their works.

### The Sea – J. A. Nairn

Τῆς Ἑλλάδος οὐδὲν μέρος πολὺ τῆς θαλάττης ἀπέχει. μεταξὺ γὰρ τῆς Εὐρώπης καὶ τῆς Ἀσίας πολλαὶ νῆσοί εἰσι, καὶ ἐν τῇ χώρᾳ αὐτῇ πολλοὶ λιμένες, ὥστε οἱ ἀπ᾽ Εὐρώπης πρὸς Ἀσίαν πλέοντες γῆν ἀεί ποθ᾽ ὁρῶσιν· ἀγαθοὶ δ᾽ ὄντες ναῦται οἱ Ἕλληνες ἦλθον ἐπὶ τὴν Ἰωνίαν καὶ τὴν Λιβύην, καὶ Αἴγυπτον, καὶ δὴ καὶ ἐπὶ τὴν Βρεταννικήν, καὶ διὰ τοῦ Ἑλλησπόντου

No one of the Greeks is much far from the value of the sea. For between Europe and Asia there are many islands, and many ponds in the very countryside, so that those sailing from Europe towards Asia seldom see the land: and the Greek sailors, being good, came upon Ionia and Libya, and Egypt, and in fact upon Britain, and throughout the Hellespont upon the black

[1] Possibly a reference to democracy and philosophy in particular.

[2] Standard philhellene talk. Pretty exciting introduction!

ἐπὶ τὸν Εὔξεινον πόντον, καὶ ἀποικίας ᾤκισαν. ὡς καλὸν τὸ χρῶμα τῆς ἐκεῖ, τῆς Αἰγαίας θαλάττης! τῷ οἴνῳ προσόμοιον ἔφασαν εἶναι οἱ ποιηταί.

sea, and settled colonies. So beautiful is the color of that place, the Aegean sea! The poets said it was similar to wine.

## The Land – J. A. Nairn

Μικρὰ δὴ χώρα ἡ Ἑλλάς· καὶ πολλὰ μὲν ὄρη ὀλίγα δὲ πεδία ἔχει, ποταμοὺς δ᾽ οὐ μακρούς. τὰ δ᾽ ὄρη, τοὺς Ἕλληνας ἀπ᾽ ἀλλήλων ἀποτέμνοντα, ἀπίστους πρός τοὺς ὁμόρους ἐποίει, ῥᾴδιον γὰρ οὐκ ἦν συνελθεῖν. καὶ πρὸς τοὺς ἔξω πολεμίους τοῦτο μέγαν κίνδυνον παρεῖχεν, ἐπεὶ οὐχ ὡς ἓν ἔθνος ἀλλ᾽ ὡς πόλεις ἑκάστη καθ᾽ ἑκάστην διῆγον. τῶν δὲ πόλεων ὀνόματα τῶν λαμπροτάτων γράψω· Σπάρτη, Ἀθῆναι, Θῆβαι, Ἄργος, Κόρινθος. ἐπολέμουν πρὸς ἀλλήλας αὗται αἱ πόλεις πολλάκις, εἰρήνην δ᾽ ἦγον οὐ πολλάκις.

The Greek land is small: on the one hand, it has many mountains, but it has few plains, and no large rivers. And the rivers, severing the Greeks from each other, were creating distrust against neighbors, for it was not easy to assemble. And this was a great danger outside of wars, because each lived according to each, not separated by race but by cities[3]. I shall write the names of the most famous cities: Sparta, Athens, Thebes, Argos, Corinth. These cities were often at war with each other, and were often not at peace.

[3]Unsure about this translation.